

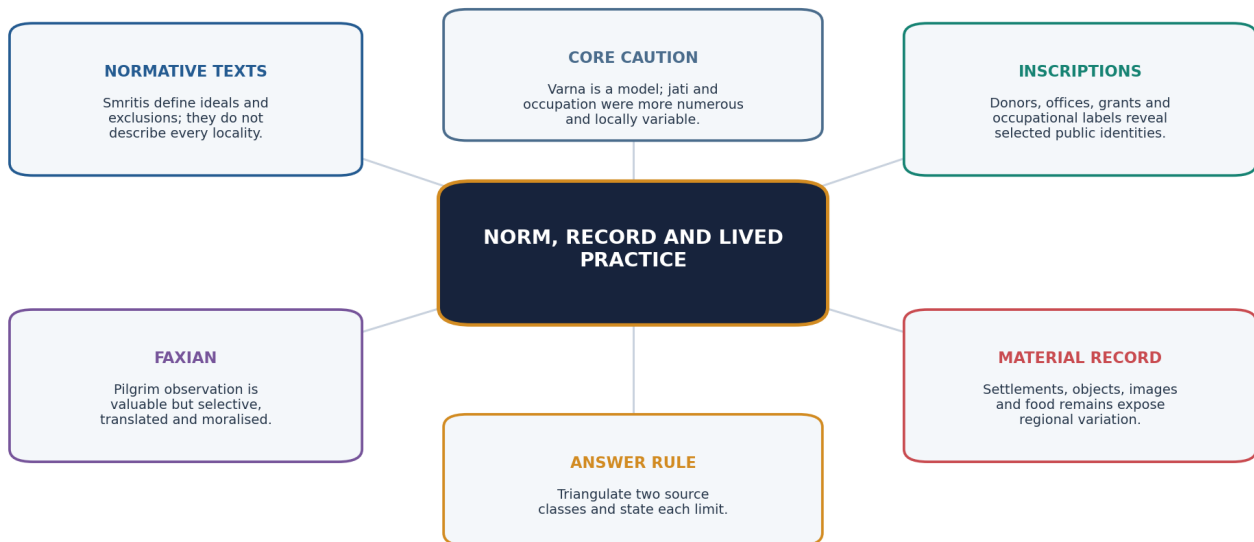
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Life & Culture in the Gupta Age - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Social hierarchy: evidence before assertion

Original deterministic UPSC study schematic



Do not turn a prescriptive verse or one traveller's sentence into a census of Gupta India.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Life & Culture in the Gupta Age - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

Which source pairing best tests a claim about Gupta social hierarchy?

- A. Smriti and inscription
- B. Only one coin type
- C. Only a modern textbook label
- D. Only a later legend

Answer: A. A prescriptive text establishes the norm; an inscription can test selected public practice.

Learning MCQ 02

Kulyavapa and dronavapa are best understood as

- A. marriage forms
- B. land-measure terms
- C. coin denominations
- D. guild offices

Answer: B. The official 2020 paper asks this exact distinction; they denote measurement of land.

Learning MCQ 03

Which statement is safest regarding Gupta-age women?

- A. Purdah was universal
- B. Women were absent from production
- C. Patriarchal norms coexisted with uneven agency
- D. All women enjoyed equal inheritance

Answer: C. The evidence supports a differentiated, source-aware conclusion.

Learning MCQ 04

Faxian's account should primarily be read as

- A. a Gupta revenue manual
- B. a complete census
- C. a neutral legal code
- D. a Buddhist pilgrim's situated account

Answer: D. His route and religious purpose shape both observation and silence.

Learning MCQ 05

The Mandasor silk-weaver inscriptions are especially useful for linking

- A. migration, corporate craft identity and patronage
- B. only village taxation
- C. only royal conquest
- D. only Buddhist doctrine

Answer: A. They connect mobility, guild identity, wealth and temple support.

Learning MCQ 06

Which is the correct chronology?

- A. Brahmagupta before Aryabhata
- B. Aryabhata before Varahamihira
- C. Vagbhata securely under Samudragupta
- D. Varahamihira before Kalidasa with certainty

Answer: B. Aryabhata is 499 CE; Varahamihira belongs to the sixth century.

Learning MCQ 07

The strongest caution about Aryabhata is that

- A. he wrote no mathematical work
- B. he lived in the Mauryan age
- C. place-value use is not the same as inventing zero
- D. he denied astronomy

Answer: C. Zero, place value and epigraphic notation have distinct histories.

Learning MCQ 08

Ajanta's major late phase is best described as

- A. Gupta imperial only
- B. Mauryan imperial
- C. Kushana court
- D. Vakataka-context within the Gupta-Vakataka age

Answer: D. This preserves the political and chronological caveat.

Learning MCQ 09

Sanskritisation in this period is best treated as

- A. adoption and local adaptation of prestige idioms
- B. one royal language law
- C. extinction of all Prakrits
- D. proof of universal literacy

Answer: A. It was negotiated and multilingual.

Learning MCQ 10

Sarnath Gupta sculpture is especially associated with

- A. blue-grey schist
- B. buff/cream sandstone and subtle robe treatment
- C. black basalt only
- D. bronze Nataraja

Answer: B. The material and modelling distinguish the Sarnath convention.

Learning MCQ 11

Which temple claim is safest?

- A. Bhitargaon is a rock-cut cave
- B. All Gupta temples had later Khajuraho scale
- C. Deogarh is an early sixth-century Vaishnava structural temple
- D. Sanchi Temple 17 is a Chola gopuram

Answer: C. Deogarh is a key early structural and iconographic example.

Learning MCQ 12

The Golden Age label is best evaluated as

- A. equally valid for every region and class
- B. a neutral census term
- C. false because no achievements occurred
- D. useful for classical production but socially uneven

Answer: D. This is the required graded verdict.

Learning MCQ 13

Which evidence most directly demonstrates plural patronage?

- A. Udayagiri's multiple religious presences and varied donors
- B. absence of all Buddhist sites
- C. one later court legend
- D. one modern nationalist slogan

Answer: A. Udayagiri combines Vaishnava royal imagery with Shaiva and Jaina presence.

Learning MCQ 14

Mitakshara and Dayabhaga should be treated as

- A. two Buddhist monasteries
- B. later Hindu-law commentarial schools
- C. two Gupta coin series
- D. two Gupta temple plans

Answer: B. They are later legal schools and must not be backdated.

Learning MCQ 15

Which claim about Kalidasa is most defensible?

- A. His date is fixed by a birth inscription
- B. Every navaratna legend is contemporary
- C. His works are secure but exact court association is debated
- D. He wrote the Aryabhatiya

Answer: C. The works are firmer evidence than the later biography.

Learning MCQ 16

A social-history answer should conclude with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The directive requires evaluation, not celebration.

Workbook MCQ 01

Which source pairing best tests a claim about Gupta social hierarchy?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. A prescriptive text establishes the norm; an inscription can test selected public practice.

Workbook MCQ 02

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Answer: B. The official 2020 paper asks this exact distinction; they denote measurement of land.

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Which statement is safest regarding Gupta-age women?

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Workbook MCQ 04

Faxian's account should primarily be read as

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- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
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Answer: D. His route and religious purpose shape both observation and silence.

Workbook MCQ 05

The Mandasor silk-weaver inscriptions are especially useful for linking

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. They connect mobility, guild identity, wealth and temple support.

Workbook MCQ 06

Which is the correct chronology?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Aryabhatiya is 499 CE; Varahamihira belongs to the sixth century.

Workbook MCQ 07

The strongest caution about Aryabhata is that

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Zero, place value and epigraphic notation have distinct histories.

Workbook MCQ 08

Ajanta's major late phase is best described as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. This preserves the political and chronological caveat.

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Sanskritisation in this period is best treated as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. It was negotiated and multilingual.

Workbook MCQ 10

Sarnath Gupta sculpture is especially associated with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. The material and modelling distinguish the Sarnath convention.

Workbook MCQ 11

Which temple claim is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Deogarh is a key early structural and iconographic example.

Workbook MCQ 12

The Golden Age label is best evaluated as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. This is the required graded verdict.

Workbook MCQ 13

Which evidence most directly demonstrates plural patronage?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Udayagiri combines Vaishnava royal imagery with Shaiva and Jaina presence.

Workbook MCQ 14

Mitakshara and Dayabhaga should be treated as

- A. a ruler list
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- C. an unsupported quotation
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Answer: B. They are later legal schools and must not be backdated.

Workbook MCQ 15

Which claim about Kalidasa is most defensible?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. The works are firmer evidence than the later biography.

Workbook MCQ 16

A social-history answer should conclude with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The directive requires evaluation, not celebration.

Workbook MCQ 17

Which statement about the Mehrauli iron pillar is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Technical skill is secure; ruler identification and modern labels need caution.

Workbook MCQ 18

The Mandasor silk weavers most directly demonstrate

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. The inscriptions connect migration, occupation and religious endowment.

Workbook MCQ 19

Which statement best distinguishes stridhana?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Recognition did not make the entire property regime equal.

Workbook MCQ 20

Which is NOT a safe Gupta-age claim?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Brahmagupta is seventh-century and post-Gupta.

Workbook MCQ 21

Sanchi Temple 17 is useful as evidence for

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. It illustrates restrained early structural-temple form.

Workbook MCQ 22

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Sarnath is a major Gupta sculpture centre.

Workbook MCQ 23

The term 'Gupta-Vakataka age' is especially useful for

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. It preserves broad chronology and actual patronage context.

Workbook MCQ 24

Which conclusion is least defensible?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The universal prosperity claim contradicts hierarchy and labour evidence.

Workbook MCQ 25

Which source is most directly prescriptive?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Smritis set normative rules.

Workbook MCQ 26

A guild endowment primarily indicates

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. It shows historically specific financial and corporate capacity.

Workbook MCQ 27

Which statement about Kalidasa is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Works and later court legend must be separated.

Workbook MCQ 28

Which answer structure best fits 'critically examine Golden Age'?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Critical examination needs criterion and balance.

Workbook MCQ 29

Which is a strong source-limit sentence?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Genre-aware use is neither credulous nor dismissive.

Workbook MCQ 30

Aryabhata's eclipse explanation relied on

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. His astronomy explained eclipses through shadows.

Workbook MCQ 31

Which statement about language is correct?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Court prestige did not eliminate other languages.

Workbook MCQ 32

Which is the proper ownership statement?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Ownership must reflect actual syllabus and source function.

Workbook MCQ 33

The strongest use of Faxian is

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. His account is valuable when route and purpose are stated.

Workbook MCQ 34

Which is correctly paired?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Amarakosha is traditionally attributed to Amarasimha.

Workbook MCQ 35

What most directly complicates a universal Golden Age?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Social distribution is the decisive test.

Workbook MCQ 36

Which claim requires the strongest caveat?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. Nalanda developed over time.

Workbook MCQ 37

Varna should be used as

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. The model/practice distinction is fundamental.

Workbook MCQ 38

The principal value of Ajanta for daily life is

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Visual evidence is rich but composed.

Workbook MCQ 39

Which statement about Puranas is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Their formation was cumulative.

Workbook MCQ 40

A good 20-mark conclusion should

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. The verdict should follow from the demonstrated criterion.

Workbook MCQ 41

Which named example best links artisans and patronage?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. Mandasor is the relevant Gupta-age corporate example.

Workbook MCQ 42

Deogarh is primarily associated here with

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. The Dashavatara temple anchors early sixth-century architecture.

Workbook MCQ 43

Which comparison is defensible?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. The comparison should avoid caricature while naming real differences.

Workbook MCQ 44

The phrase 'achievement for whom?' tests

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. It turns Golden Age into an evaluative question.

Workbook MCQ 45

Which route is correct for the 2025 Faxian question?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: A. This is the explicit anti-duplication boundary.

Workbook MCQ 46

Which statement about Buddhism is safest?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: B. Continuity coexisted with Puranic expansion.

Workbook MCQ 47

Which scientific figure is post-Gupta?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: C. Brahmagupta's 628 work is post-Gupta.

Workbook MCQ 48

Which is an invalid inference from Prabhavati Gupta?

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits

Answer: D. An exceptional elite case cannot establish universal status.

Remedial 1 - Zero claim

Correct the statement: 'Aryabhata invented zero.'

Correction: Aryabhata's 499 CE procedures presuppose decimal place-value logic. The conceptual and epigraphic histories of zero are separate; Brahmagupta's explicit arithmetic rules belong to 628 CE.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 2 - Ajanta ownership

Correct the statement: 'Ajanta is Gupta imperial painting.'

Correction: The principal late fifth-century phase is chiefly Vakataka-context production within the broader Gupta-Vakataka cultural age.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 3 - Women

Correct the statement: 'Prabhavati Gupta proves women had equal status.'

Correction: She proves specific elite female authority. General status needs normative, inscriptional, labour and property evidence.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 4 - Faxian

Correct the statement: 'Faxian gives an objective census.'

Correction: He provides situated pilgrim observation. Corroborate route-specific claims and do not infer from silence.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 5 - Golden Age

Correct the statement: 'Social inequality means there was no cultural achievement.'

Correction: Critical evaluation preserves achievement while testing its social and spatial distribution.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 6 - Temple style

Correct the statement: 'Gupta temples were mature Khajuraho-style Nagara temples.'

Correction: They represent earlier structural experiments; describe plan, material and superstructure before applying later style vocabulary.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 7 - Mitakshara

Correct the statement: 'Mitakshara was a Gupta legal code.'

Correction: It is Vijaneshwara's later commentary on Yajnavalkya Smriti; Dayabhaga is also later.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

Remedial 8 - Sanskrit

Correct the statement: 'Sanskrit replaced all other languages.'

Correction: It became a transregional prestige idiom while Prakrits and regional speech persisted.

Why this earns marks: the correction is dated, bounded and source-aware.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Critically examine the description of the Gupta age as a Golden Age.

Demand and thesis (20 marks): The label captures a real classical florescence but fails as a universal social judgement.

Evidence density target: 8-10 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Literary and scientific production was exceptional. [EVIDENCE] Kalidasa's drama and kavya and Aryabhata's Aryabhatiya (499 CE). [SIGNIFICANCE] They created influential literary and mathematical-astronomical canons. [LIMIT] Both belong to specialist, largely elite knowledge worlds.

[CLAIM] Art and sacred architecture developed durable forms. [EVIDENCE] Sarnath Buddha images, Udayagiri Varaha, Sanchi Temple 17, Bhitargaon and Deogarh. [SIGNIFICANCE] Image, deity, patron and structural shrine became integrated. [LIMIT] Dating is not equally secure and later Nagara scale must not be projected backward.

[CLAIM] Cultural integration widened. [EVIDENCE] Sanskrit prashastis, Puranic redaction, Vaishnava-Shaiva-Shakta traditions, continuing Buddhist and Jain institutions. [SIGNIFICANCE] A transregional prestige idiom coexisted with sectarian plurality. [LIMIT] Sanskrit prominence did not erase multilingualism.

[CLAIM] The social base was unequal. [EVIDENCE] Faxian's Chandala passage, vishti, patriarchal Smriti norms and agrarian grants. [SIGNIFICANCE] Exclusion and labour obligations financed or accompanied elite visibility. [LIMIT] Sources are normative and regionally uneven, so inequality must be demonstrated without claiming a uniform condition.

[CLAIM] The label is spatially selective. [EVIDENCE] Ajanta's Vakataka setting and distinct peninsular trajectories. [SIGNIFICANCE] 'Gupta age' extends beyond direct Gupta rule. [LIMIT] It cannot replace regional histories.

Conclusion: The Gupta age was classical in enduring production, but golden only as a bounded historiographical description of selected achievements, not as a verdict on every region or social group.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Discuss the relationship between social hierarchy and cultural production in the Gupta age.

Demand and thesis (15 marks): Cultural production drew resources and legitimacy from a hierarchical agrarian order while also creating integrative languages and institutions.

Evidence density target: 6-7 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Agrarian surplus enabled patronage. [EVIDENCE] land-grant charters, kulyavapa/dronavapa measures and labour dues. [SIGNIFICANCE] Courts and religious beneficiaries could support texts, temples and specialists. [LIMIT] grant rights varied.

[CLAIM] Corporate wealth widened patronage. [EVIDENCE] Mandasor silk weavers and their Sun-temple support. [SIGNIFICANCE] Artisans and migrants were cultural agents, not passive subjects. [LIMIT] one inscription is not an all-India guild map.

[CLAIM] Hierarchy shaped access and representation. [EVIDENCE] Smriti norms, stridhana limits and Faxian's Chandala passage. [SIGNIFICANCE] education, property and public visibility were unequal. [LIMIT] normative and traveller evidence requires corroboration.

[CLAIM] Culture also integrated diverse regions. [EVIDENCE] Sanskrit inscription, Puranic traditions and shared iconographies. [SIGNIFICANCE] elites could communicate across polities. [LIMIT] Prakrits and local languages persisted.

Conclusion: Gupta culture was neither detached genius nor mere ideological cover: it was an unequal social process in which surplus, rank, mobility and plural patronage interacted.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Explain the contribution of Gupta-age mathematics, astronomy and metallurgy, with chronology cautions.

Demand and thesis (10 marks): The secure contribution is substantial when Aryabhata and material metallurgy are separated from later attributions.

Evidence density target: 4-5 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Aryabhata synthesised mathematics and astronomy. [EVIDENCE] Aryabhatiya, 499 CE, with pi approximation, trigonometric procedures, eclipse explanation and earth-rotation argument. [SIGNIFICANCE] It systematised computation and astronomical reasoning. [LIMIT] place-value use is not a claim that he invented zero.

[CLAIM] The tradition continued after the main Gupta phase. [EVIDENCE] Varahamihira in the sixth century and Brahmagupta's Brahmasphutasiddhanta in 628 CE. [SIGNIFICANCE] classical science was cumulative. [LIMIT] Brahmagupta is post-Gupta.

[CLAIM] Metallurgy achieved high technical control. [EVIDENCE] Mehrauli iron pillar. [SIGNIFICANCE] large wrought-iron manufacture and corrosion resistance. [LIMIT] the king Chandra identification is debated.

Conclusion: Precise chronology converts a triumphalist list into a defensible history of cumulative scientific practice.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

The separate workbook PDF contains the same PYQ, MCQ, remedial and original Mains material below.

Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)

With reference to the history of India, the terms "kulyavapa" and "dronavapa" denote: (a) measurement of land (b) coins of different monetary value (c) classification of urban land (d) religious rituals.

Status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - OFFICIAL 2020 KEY NOT HELD LOCALLY.

Answer / route: A - measurement of land.

The terms occur in land-recording and agrarian-measure contexts. The distractors shift them into coinage, urban classification or ritual. Confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)

With reference to scholars/litterateurs of ancient India: 1. Panini is associated with Pushyamitra Shunga. 2. Amarasingha is associated with Harshavardhana. 3. Kalidasa is associated with Chandragupta II. Which statements are correct?

Status: INFERRED ANSWER - OFFICIAL 2020 KEY NOT HELD LOCALLY.

Answer / route: Statement 3 only; option C in the locally extracted Set A paper.

Panini predates Pushyamitra; Amarasingha is traditionally associated with the Gupta/Vikramaditya milieu rather than Harsha; the exam convention accepts Kalidasa-Chandragupta II while scholarship still cautions that exact court biography is debated. Confidence: high for exam elimination.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)

Locally audited demand: distinguish Mitakshara and Dayabhaga systems of property inheritance.

Status: ROUTED DEMAND; EXACT LOCAL PAPER/KEY NOT HELD. PROVISIONAL CONCEPT SOLUTION, NOT AN OFFICIAL KEY.

Answer / route: Core distinction: Mitakshara recognises a son's interest by birth in joint ancestral property; Dayabhaga generally opens the son's succession after the father's death.

Do not treat the schools as Gupta codes. Mitakshara is Vijnaneshwara's later commentary on Yajnavalkya Smriti; Dayabhaga is associated with Jimutavahana. The question is cross-temporal legal history.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)

Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. (15 marks, 250 words)

Status: VERIFIED ROUTING; Gupta culture supported here, Gupta polity Topic 20, Chola context Topic 27, form depth Indian Art and Culture.

Answer / route: Cross-owned model route.

Thesis: both periods created enduring cultural repertoires through different political economies. Gupta evidence: Kalidasa, Aryabhata, Sarnath/Mathura sculpture, early structural temples, Puranic plurality and Sanskrit prestige, qualified by regional patronage and social inequality. Chola evidence: Brihadishvara and other Great Living Chola Temples, bronze Nataraja, Tamil inscriptions, temple institutions and maritime-linked patronage, qualified by regional diversity. Comparison: Gupta contribution is especially canonical in Sanskrit literary-scientific and iconic vocabularies; Chola contribution is especially monumental, inscription-rich and temple-institutional. Why this earns marks: balanced periods, named evidence, comparison, qualification and direct discussion.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Verified PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Verified PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)

Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of: Samudragupta / Chandragupta II / Kumaragupta I / Skandagupta.

Status: OFFICIAL 2025 SET A QUESTION AND KEY LOCALLY AVAILABLE; PRIMARY OWNER TOPIC 20.

Answer / route: B - Chandragupta II.

Faxian travelled c. 399-414 CE, overlapping Chandragupta II. Topic 21 uses the item to teach traveller-source limits.

Why this earns marks: ownership, answer-key status, evidence and limitation are explicit.

Original solved Mains - Explain how sources shape our understanding of daily life in the Gupta age.

Demand and thesis (10 marks): Daily life is recoverable only through triangulation because every source overrepresents a particular social world.

Evidence density target: 4-5 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Normative texts reveal household and hierarchy ideals. [EVIDENCE] Smriti rules on guardianship and property. [SIGNIFICANCE] They disclose the elite social order. [LIMIT] They are prescriptive.

[CLAIM] Traveller observation adds selected practice. [EVIDENCE] Faxian's Chandala passage. [SIGNIFICANCE] It records exclusion. [LIMIT] It is route- and purpose-bound.

[CLAIM] Images and objects recover material and performative life. [EVIDENCE] Ajanta dress and gesture, terracotta and pottery. [SIGNIFICANCE] They widen the record beyond law. [LIMIT] artistic convention and survival bias remain.

Conclusion: The strongest reconstruction names the source, the social location and the confidence level for every detail.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Original solved Mains - Analyse the role of Sanskritisation in Gupta-age cultural integration.

Demand and thesis (15 marks): Sanskritisation created a shared elite idiom but operated through regional negotiation rather than language replacement.

Evidence density target: 6-7 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Sanskrit connected courts. [EVIDENCE] prashastis and kavya. [SIGNIFICANCE] rulers entered a transregional political-aesthetic field. [LIMIT] inscriptions do not prove popular speech.

[CLAIM] Puranic myths and sectarian icons widened cultural repertoires. [EVIDENCE] Udayagiri Varaha and Deogarh Vaishnava programme. [SIGNIFICANCE] belief, kingship and sacred space became mutually legible. [LIMIT] Shaiva, Shakta, Buddhist and Jain traditions continued.

[CLAIM] Local agents adapted the idiom. [EVIDENCE] regional courts, donors and workshops. [SIGNIFICANCE] integration did not erase locality. [LIMIT] Sanskritisation should not be described as frictionless.

[CLAIM] Multilingualism remained. [EVIDENCE] Prakrit and regional speech traditions. [SIGNIFICANCE] the process was layered. [LIMIT] literacy and language use cannot be quantified.

Conclusion: Sanskritisation was powerful because it was portable and adaptable, not because it created cultural uniformity.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

Original solved Mains - Assess the relationship between religion, royal power and artistic production in the Gupta-Vakataka age.

Demand and thesis (20 marks): Religion supplied symbols of sovereignty and fields of patronage, while artistic production depended on plural donors, workshops and regional courts.

Evidence density target: 8-10 named units, each linked to significance.

Model answer:

[CLAIM] Royal Vaishnavism translated power into cosmic order. [EVIDENCE] Udayagiri Varaha and Garuda symbolism. [SIGNIFICANCE] the king could be associated with protection and restoration. [LIMIT] iconography is not a literal political event.

[CLAIM] Structural temples stabilised deity-centred sacred space. [EVIDENCE] Sanchi 17, Deogarh and Bhitargaon. [SIGNIFICANCE] patronage joined image, ritual and architecture. [LIMIT] chronology and reconstruction differ by site.

[CLAIM] Plural traditions remained productive. [EVIDENCE] Shaiva and Jaina evidence at Udayagiri, Buddhist networks described by Faxian. [SIGNIFICANCE] royal preference did not eliminate multiple communities. [LIMIT] surviving monuments are uneven.

[CLAIM] Regional courts were decisive. [EVIDENCE] Vakataka-context Ajanta. [SIGNIFICANCE] the age's finest painting was not simply imperial Gupta output. [LIMIT] cave phases and patrons require care.

[CLAIM] Non-royal patrons mattered. [EVIDENCE] Mandasor silk weavers and lay donative traditions. [SIGNIFICANCE] merchants and artisans converted wealth into sacred culture. [LIMIT] corporate inscriptions are selective.

Conclusion: Gupta-Vakataka art was a negotiated field where sovereignty, devotion, corporate wealth and workshop skill converged without producing religious uniformity.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

These topic-specific register notes are deliberately last.

Demand decoding: Treat "Verified PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Verified PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.